Kokish Relay

Print Page Download PDF

636 Shares

Email Share Post

Balanced hands that are too strong to open 1NT (15-17 HCP) are expected to use the following Standard American sequences. The 2♣ auctions waste a lot of space and are somewhat wide-ranging in nature.

Opener's strength	Opening Bid
20-21 HCP	Open 2NT
22-24 HCP	Open 2♣ and rebid 2NT
25-27 HCP	Open 2♣ and rebid 3NT
28-30 HCP	Open 2♣ and rebid 4NT
31-32 HCP	Open 2♣ and rebid 5NT

To improve on this, Canadian expert Eric Kokish proposed a more compact structure. After a 2♣ opening bid and a 2♦ negative response, opener should still rebid 2NT to show 22-24 balanced points, like so:

	Opener	Partner
♠AKQ	2♣	2♦
♥AK	2NT	
♦A765		
♣K983		

However, a balanced hand with 25+ points should rebid an artificial 2♥ as a relay to 2♠. This shows either 1) a balanced hand with 25+ points, or 2) a genuine heart suit.

Opener's rebids after the 2♠ relay:

Opener's Rebid	Meaning
2NT	25+ points, game-forcing[1]
3♣	5+ hearts and 4+ clubs
3♦	5+ hearts and 4+ diamonds
3♥	6+ hearts[2]
3♠	5+ hearts and 4+ spades

[1] If you prefer, 2NT can be eased to 24+ points. This makes it riskier to force game, but also allows the immediate 2NT rebid to be tightened to 22-23 points.

[2] Balanced hands with 5 hearts should rebid 2NT, either directly or indirectly.

Kokish originally called his contraption "Birthright", although it is more popularly known as the Kokish Relay.

In his book "The No-Trump Zone", American expert Danny Kleinman states, "The Kokish Relay loses responder's 'second negative' or delayd positive response when opener has a big heart hand, but gains by replacing awkward 3NT sequences with smooth 2NT auctions when opener has a big notrump hand. I'm not confident that the benefits outweigh the drawbacks."

Examples

Opener	Responder
♠AK	♠J8732
♥QJT	♥87642
♦AKQ2	♦5
♣AK86	♣54

Opener	Responder
2♣ (1)	2♦ (2)
2♥ (3)	2♠ (4)
2NT (5)	3♦ (6)
3♥	3♠ (7)
4♥	Pass

1. Strong and artificial
2. 0-7 points, negative or waiting
3. Kokish Relay
4. Completing the relay
5. 25+ points, balanced and game-forcing
6. Jacoby transfer
7. Showing 5 spades along with the 5 hearts

Note that the partnership would have lacked an extra level of bidding space if opener had rebid 3NT immediately.

Opener	Responder
♠AT3	♠K42
♥AKJ872	♥95
♦AKT	♦653
♣A	♣T8765

Opener	Responder
2♣ (1)	2♦ (2)
2♥ (3)	2♠ (4)
3♥ (5)	4♥
Pass	

1. Strong and artificial
2. 0-7 points, negative or waiting
3. Kokish Relay
4. Completing the relay
5. 6+ hearts, game-forcing

Opener	Responder
♠T6	♠Q7542
♥AQT64	♥973
♦AKJ	♦T765
♣AKQ	♣7

Opener	Responder
2♣ (1)	2♦ (2)
2NT(3)	3♥ (4)
3♠ (5)	Pass

1. Strong and artificial
2. 0-7 points, negative or waiting
3. 22-24 balanced
4. Jacoby transfer
5. Completing the transfer

Employing the Kokish Relay means that opener can't rebid a natural 2♥ with an unguarded spade doubleton. In this case the partnership ends up in the inferior major suit.

See also

- Strong 2♣ Opening Bid
  The Standard American method of using a 2♣ as a strong, artificial opening bid.

